

Photo Essay: How to Build a
Nova Scotian
Grand Banks Dory

By Jeff Spira



Plans available at:

<http://SpiralInternational.com/>

How to Build a Nova Scotian Grand Banks Dory

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In Lunenburg, Nova Scotia, throughout the 1800's the finest dories in the world were being built by two different boat builders. These craft served as fishing boats launched from the decks of schooners and fishing practically in the middle of the North Atlantic, year-round. This Nova Scotian was derived from the original Grand Banks fishing dories. You can launch these boats through the surf, keep going in weather that drives everyone else back to the beach, and load more into this boat than boats substantially larger. A better rough water pulling boat cannot be found anywhere.

The boat shown in these photos was built by Kevin Power in 2017.



Like all of the Spira International Ply on Frame boats, the frames are built first. The plans give you precise dimensions to build the frames



The strongback is built next. It serves as a kind of jig to ensure the boat is straight and proportioned correctly. The plans detail this member as well. The stands may be built from any extra or scrap lumber you may have access to. The strongback also holds the elements up so that you can work on it at a comfortable height.



The centers of the frames are cut with a notch for the keelson to be attached.

Note that the frame cutouts are wider than the keelson. This leaves gaps on either side of the frames that become limber holes, that let water

collect to the lowest point of the boat and make draining (with drain plugs) easier when the boat is out of the water or pumping the bilge when the boat is in the water.

The frames are then assembled onto the strongback at the heights described on the drawings.



The keelson, a standard sized piece of lumber, is glued and screwed to the frames and stem (at the bow.)

The frames are notched and longitudinal elements called the sheer clamp and chine log are added from the stem to the transom, and attached to each frame.



The frame is now a stiff structure and it is used as a pattern to cut out the plywood covering. Panels are cut to fit and glued and screwed to the framing, the frames, the sheer clamp, the chine log and to the keelson as well.



Continue covering the sides of the boat and the bottom with plywood. Glue and screw in place.



Once the boat is fully covered you can start filling the separations, screw holes and any cracks you find in the hull. Most builders use sawdust mixed with epoxy resin, but other combinations of things like talcum power, microspheres (which sand the best) or silica may also be used with resin to form effective filler putty.



Two layers of 6 oz fiberglass cloth is used on the outside to seal and strengthen the hull. These may be put on at the same time, and allowed to set together.





Sand,
primer, and
paint the
fiberglassed
hull, then flip
over to start
working on
the inside.



Decking, seats, flotation chambers and accessories are added next.



Give the inside a finish or paint job, and you're now ready to get it wet.



You can find out more and download free study plans which include a sailing rig for this boat here:

http://SpiralInternational.com/hp_nova.php